The “Bipolar Disorder” of Social Discourse: The Fan Phenomenon and Its Cultural Symptoms under Digital Capitalism

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Since the era of data-driven ranking on Sina Weibo's “Super Topics” began in 2016, a distinctive culture of fan circles has taken shape on internet social media platforms. Grounded in fans' psychological identification, it replaces artistic and aesthetic criteria with traffic metrics and sparks intense discursive battles between different fan groups. In 2021, the central cyberspace authorities launched the “Qinglang: Rectifying Disorder in Fan Circles” campaign to address this phenomenon. Such extreme emotions and expressions, saturated with tension and antagonism, readily lapse into polarized states of sudden, euphoric excitement or hatred and anger. Like “bipolar affective disorder” in its pathological sense - a condition involving manic episodes accompanied by depression[1] - they produce tension and imbalance in the online ecosystem.

Although emotions are strongly experiential or subjective, they are not merely biological manifestations. They are also constituted through social cognition and possess cultural, historical, and political dimensions.[2]

The bipolar symptoms arising from individual identification within Chinese fan circles, the individual and social cognitive distortions produced by the fan logic of this psychological identification, and the mechanisms of digital capital operating behind online platforms require an in-depth humanistic interpretation. This interpretation must situate individuals, society, and the logic of capital within their important interactive relationships in an actor-network.

I. Psychological Roots: The Pre-Oedipal Object Relationship between Fans and Celebrities

1. From Individual Adoration to Group Identification

On June 6, 2016, “#Lu Han#” became the first Super Topic on Sina Weibo, marking the establishment of traffic data as a direct measure of celebrity value. Fans were alienated from traditional, real-world “star chasers”[A] into “data laborers,” a form of immaterial labor specific to the Web 2.0 era.

Fan groups known as data laborers have strict organizational structures and divisions of labor. Unlike relatively loosely organized traditional star chasers, the fans of different traffic-driven celebrities have distinct support colors, slogans, and even hand gestures. One-way individual adoration of a celebrity becomes collective psychological identification.

Most fans experience a psychological transition from self-identification through individual projection to identification with a particular celebrity's fan group, gaining a strong sense of belonging. “When group identity is challenged or threatened, group members adopt various strategies to defend that identity and preserve self-esteem.”[3]

This psychological need for group identification is more than simple conformity. Fans in fan-circle culture achieve what psychology calls a “social arousal effect”: when individuals are in a group, “the group can produce a sense of excitement, a feeling of being drawn to a force greater than oneself.”[4] As individuals remain aroused within the group, their identities as autonomous and independent persons become increasingly blurred and self-awareness weakens. They enter instead a flattened, homogeneous, and even extreme psychological state. This behavior helps fans maintain and reinforce their fan identities; it is also a psychological state reinforced by the opposing group of “anti-fans.”

2. The Pre-Oedipal Psychological State

“Pre-Oedipal” refers to the infant's state before identification with the father and the transition from individual to subject. In this state, an exceptionally complex relationship of dependence exists between mother and infant.[B][5] Within such a pre-Oedipal state, fans understand not only celebrities but also matters surrounding them as performing the “maternal” function of warm and attentive care. For instance, when describing their relationship with an idol, fans habitually use kinship terms such as “older brother” and “younger brother,” establishing an imagined familial relationship.

When an idol falls from grace, fans use the term “house collapse” (tafang), a phrase charged with the emotional attachment to the space of home in cultural geography. At the psychoanalytic level, this pre-Oedipal state of the self is also, to some extent, what John Fiske means when he says that “the discrimination and distinction of fandom derive from self-identification.”[6] Starting from imagined kinship, fans construct imaginary relationships of identification with celebrities, others, and the world.

The fan as self and the idol as object form a pre-Oedipal object relationship. Once external reality interrupts the identity relation between fan and celebrity, the fan as self loses pleasure and experiences fear of the real world. Like an infant forcibly separated from its mother, the fan then experiences anxiety, unease, and anger. This is the psychological root of fans' efforts to defend their idols' positive images at any cost, entering what appears to be a state of extreme paranoia.

3. “Bipolar Symptoms” as a Rhetorical Figure

In this process, bipolar affective disorder functions as a symptomatic rhetorical figure for behavior. On the one hand, it appears as irrational conduct such as fighting, mutual smearing, and verbal abuse. On the other, it readily lapses into irrational psychological states such as remorse, dejection, and despondency. Figure 1 illustrates the object relationship in this pre-Oedipal state.

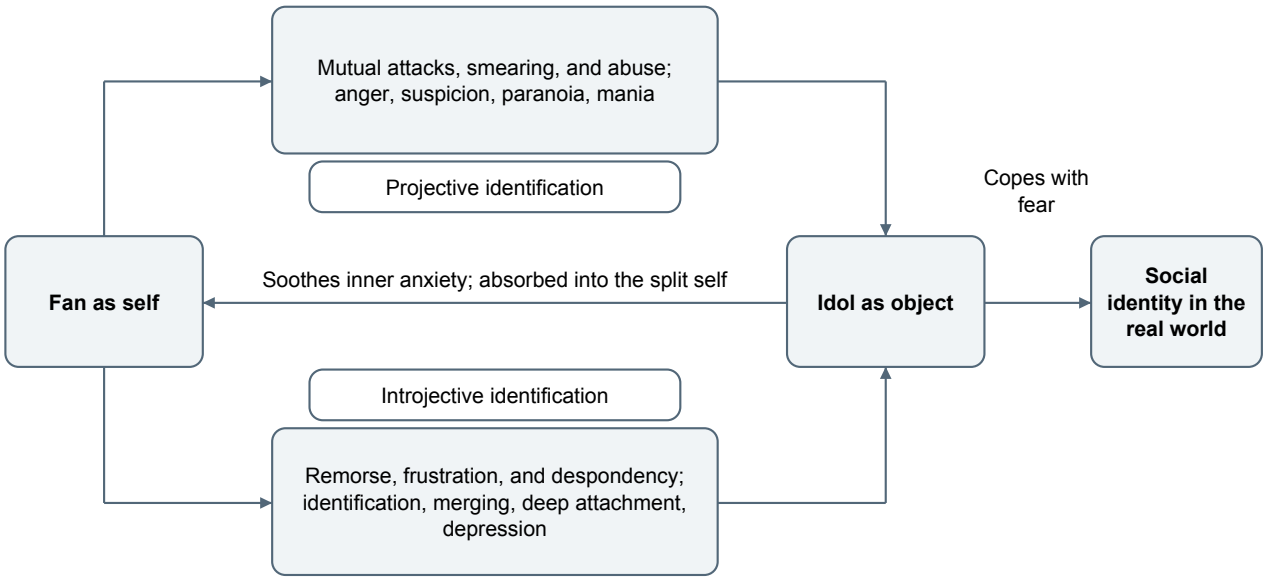


Figure 1. The object relationship between fans and idols in a pre-Oedipal state.

In the clinical manifestations of bipolar disorder, a manic episode is a necessary condition, and individuals may become hostile or even exhibit antisocial behavior. On the one hand, manic behavior appears as "euphoria, excessive pleasure, and elation," excessive enthusiasm, inflated self-regard, undue optimism, grandiosity, and poor judgment. On the other, it may rapidly turn to anger or depression, including major depressive episodes.[7] On the basis of these clinical manifestations, "bipolar symptoms" can also be applied to the study of fan culture. As Figure 1 shows, fans in a pre-Oedipal state have two markedly split forms of identification with celebrities: introjective identification and projective identification. This mode of emotional contact reflects fans' internal anxiety: they use the idol as an object, forming a pre-Oedipal state with it to defend against fear of the real world.[8]

Thus, fan behavior associated with disorder in fan circles exhibits symptoms analogous to bipolar disorder. On one side is a defensive mechanism full of projective identification, manifested clinically as anger, suspicion, paranoia, and mania. On the other is introjective identification - extreme identification and profound attachment - expressed internally as remorse and self-reproach, grief and sorrow, and imagined kinship. When negative news emerges about a celebrity, or the idol's "house collapses," for example, those first to suffer severe emotional injury are fans who regard that celebrity as their relational object. The fan-self in the pre-Oedipal state consequently displays a more negative, depressive, and irrational psychology.

As relational objects in a pre-Oedipal state, celebrity idols mediate fans' expression and alleviation of inner feelings. They do provide comfort against the anxieties of real life. For psychologically mature adults, this is also an entirely healthy psychological phenomenon.

What, then, causes this healthy psychological foundation to "fall ill" in the form of bipolar-like manic behavior? How does this relate to the real social environment in which fans live?

II. Psychic Perversion: Relational Mirrors of Real Cultural Life and Possible Treatments

1. Psychic Perversion in Reality

The psychological roots of fan-circle disorder are omnipresent in real life. Its behavioral logic to some extent replicates many phenomena of psychic perversion in reality.

First, its negative and unhealthy side generally appears as a form of psychic perversion. Fans, for example, may exhibit disordered behavior such as frenzied screaming and bodily trembling when they see images of their idols or encounter them in person. Such paranoia and fanaticism are typical oral-stage behaviors.

In 1994, for instance, the Chinese musician Gao Feng wrote the widely known patriotic song “Great China.” Its familiar lyric, “We all have a home, and its name is China,” expresses the imaginary relationship between individual and nation, a highly successful rhetorical imagination of the structural correspondence between family and state. Today, this rhetorical imagination has undergone a pronounced psychic perversion. In 2019, “fan-circle girls” launched the well-known “August 14 Grand Unity.”[C][9] Fans from different camps achieved unprecedented solidarity to protect a common “idol,” “Brother A-Zhong.” They confronted all hostile voices online in an organized and disciplined manner. Their overwhelming victory was described as a “milestone in fan-circle history.” The event's most resounding slogan was “We all have an idol, and his name is A-Zhong.” It flattened a nation with profound political significance into an “idol” within fan-circle cultural logic, identifying a national name with complex historical depth as the gendered kinship figure “Brother A-Zhong.” Through psychic perversion, fans understood the subjective imaginative logic of family-state unity as a pre-subjective, pre-Oedipal situation.

In the short term, this psychic perversion did produce positive effects: speaking actively within international public opinion, for instance. During the COVID-19 pandemic, 27 fan organizations, including the Lu Han Public Welfare Support Weibo account, formed the “666 Alliance” to support Wuhan. Their relief activities continued for over a month, and they jointly donated supplies worth nearly RMB 500,000.[10] Subsequently, fan clubs supporting Xiao Zhan, Wang Yibo, TFboys, and others voluntarily raised funds and procured medical supplies, with the highest donations exceeding RMB 2 million. To some extent, these efforts demonstrated the positive significance of the pre-Oedipal psychological roots of fans' relationships with celebrity idols.

Yet unlike celebrity idols in a pre-Oedipal state, identities associated with the state, nation, and political beliefs possess serious subjective identities that do not permit ambiguity. The pre-subjective state of the pre-Oedipal period, still within the ambiguous Real, plainly entails a fundamentally flattened, one-dimensional understanding of such serious identities. Fans in this state use infantile behavior and logic to understand historical, cultural, and political realities constituted by grand narratives. At this point, the self has already undergone a pathological change.

This change is not confined to women. The psychological roots of male fans behind the 2007 “Diba Expedition” in the sporting world, for instance, as well as internet neologisms such as “diaosi” and “Emperor Li Yi” emerging from the Li Yi Tieba forum during this period, are no different from today's fan-circle logic. They likewise exhibit a typical pre-Oedipal psychic perversion: paranoia, irrationality, extreme attachment, and lack of independent thought, thus displaying certain clinical manifestations of bipolar disorder.

2. Reverse Fan Behavior and Its Underlying Logic

As fans' object-relational dependence on idols intensifies, their application of fan-circle logic and principles to the Symbolic of the mainstream order produces a series of absurd consequences. The Symbolic, as the source mirrored by fan circles, exhibits "bipolar" clinical manifestations that are no less severe. Compared with fan logic, these may be termed "reverse fan behavior."

When people outside fan circles express disgust toward fans, for example, they habitually expose their "fan affiliations" online. From the standpoint of supposedly superior "ordinary bystanders," they judge and even personally attack them, drawing more bystanders into publicly exercising online discursive violence. A typical example is the "February 27 Incident" of 2020, triggered by Xiao Zhan fans' collective reporting of and opposition to fan-oriented derivative creative works.[D][11] It subsequently developed into mania-like behavior among the wider online public, who vented their anger through prolonged, unprovoked attacks and discursive violence against the celebrity and his fans. Xiao Zhan fans, meanwhile, suffered profound trauma after February 27 and remained in a prolonged depressive state. In fact, both those fans and the reverse fan behavior attacking them displayed typical bipolar symptoms.

It should be noted that ideology in popular culture intensifies this emotion-driven binary opposition. The psychological roots of non-fans' attacks lie in a projective need to assign blame to fans, and express a sense of superiority in cultural identity.

Examples include the supposed superiority of reason (non-fans) to emotion (fans), higher education to lower education ("they are all primary-school students"), men to women (female fans), and elites to the masses (traffic-driven celebrities). Under the ideological logic of reverse fan behavior, manic eruptions of online violence associated with bipolar symptoms intensify black-and-white opposition in public space. They conceal or attempt to repair the wider online public's exceptionally fragile, dejected, and despondent depressive condition as COVID-19 began to envelop the world in early 2020.

3. Corrective Intervention for "Bipolar Disorder"

How, then, should this hostile online ecosystem be governed? In other words, how can the psychological roots of "bipolar disorder" be treated?

Borrowing from clinical approaches to bipolar disorder in psychiatry, there are, generally speaking, three principal ways of treating a patient suffering from a mental disorder.

First, change the external environment. In August 2021, the Cyberspace Administration of China launched the "Qinglang: Rectifying Disorder in Fan Circles" campaign. The central cyberspace authorities issued the Notice on Further Strengthening the Governance of Disorder in Fan Circles to address prominent problems in Chinese online fan circles in recent years.[12] Only then did the disorder that had persisted for five years begin to ease. This top-down rectification manages the issue at a macro level, improving and reforming the wider environment. It is the first and most important means both of governing the internet environment and of treating bipolar disorder.

Second, intervene coercively in the self. Governing fan-circle disorder also requires action within fan circles themselves. After celebrities were banned, for example, Sina Weibo deliberately strengthened management of its community ecosystem, closing misleading Super Topics, disbanding groups that violated regulations, and muting or permanently closing hundreds of accounts. These measures helped curb the harmful effects of irrational behavior and extreme statements by celebrity fans and marketing accounts.

Third, provide individual psychotherapy. This is currently the most neglected yet most needed practical solution: treating individual fans' psychological trauma. Trauma is an experience that "within a very short

period subjects the mind to a stimulus of such high intensity that it cannot be dealt with or worked off in the normal way, permanently disturbing the distribution of the mind's available energy."[13] In a pre-Oedipal state, fans' selves and celebrity relational objects occupy the same identity relation as infant and mother. A celebrity's banning is therefore undoubtedly a stimulus of the "highest intensity" for fans. Abrupt rupture imposed from outside inevitably traumatizes the "infant." Moral or legal compulsion can hardly change this; psychological counselors are needed to intervene in the psychological crisis.

III. The Algorithm of Desire: Affective Labor under the Logic of Digital Capitalism

1. The Three Relational Dimensions of Data Laborers and "Data Women Workers"

Further questions need to be asked: Why are contemporary fans placed in a pre-Oedipal situation? What latent desires underlie the psychological compensation sought by the online public? And who controls our desires?

As noted earlier, unlike traditional star chasers, fans of idols in the traffic era are assigned the identity of "data laborers" or "data women workers," a fan identity "invented" in the age of digital capital.

"Data laborers," also called "data women workers" because fan communities are generally considered predominantly female, are individuals or groups, chiefly women, who invest enormous emotional energy through online media, in the form of immaterial labor, to generate traffic data for an idol or group.[E][14] In the age of digital capitalism, fans consciously reaffirm their feelings toward celebrities through creative practices: making merchandise posters and mementos, producing derivative works from original texts, and building interpersonal relationships within fan groups. This affective labor is therefore productive.[15]

Fans' self-identification is also constructed through this process and even becomes a way of understanding the world. The term "data laborers/data women workers" indicates three relational dimensions:

First, gendered labor presupposes identification with femininity within a conception of gendered divisions of labor, although such labor is not performed exclusively by women.[16]

Second, immaterial labor is "labor that produces the informational and cultural content of the commodity." It is a new social relationship integrating production and consumption, first proposed by the Italian scholar Maurizio Lazzarato.[17]

Third, affective labor is a new form of capitalist labor in the information economy proposed by Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri in Empire: immaterial labor involving the production and manipulation of affect.[18]

Disorder in fan circles is not caused solely by individual fans' behavior. It involves three dynamic relational dimensions: gendered labor integrating producers and consumers; immaterial labor producing information and cultural content; and affective labor involving the production and manipulation of affect in that process, as shown in Figure 2.

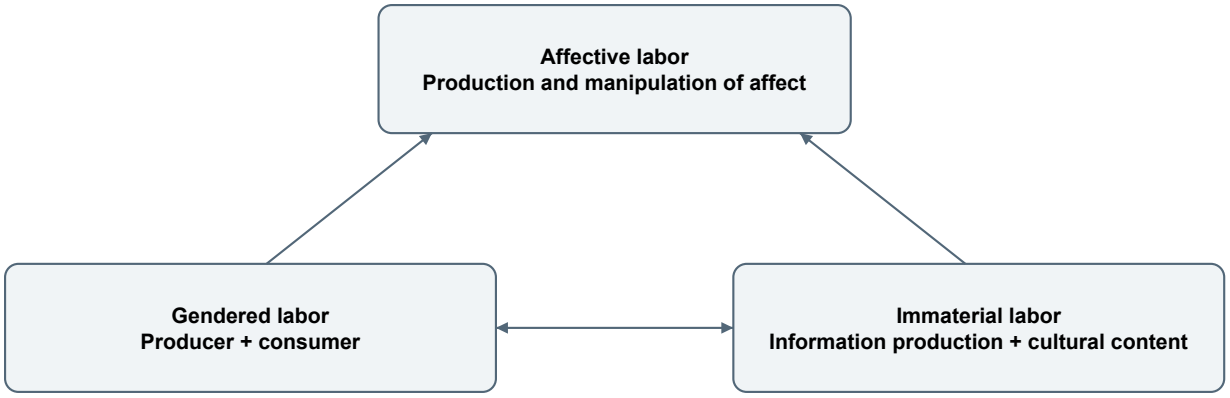


Figure 2. The relational dimensions of data laborers/data women workers: gendered, immaterial, and affective labor.

These three dynamic relational dimensions constitute both the productive logic of fan identity and the capitalist logic of the fan economy. Compared with identification with the celebrity as other in the era of traditional star chasing, fans' psychological expectations, contributions, and returns in affective labor under digital capital are fixed within a logic of self-identification. Psychologically, fans form a tenacious relationship of dependence with celebrities, ultimately feeding back into and constructing their identical status as both producers and consumers.

In idol-development programs such as Idol Producer, Produce 101, and X-Fire, for example, fans participate in the entire process of an idol's growth, from the first stage appearance to debut. This generates a strong sense of companionship and emotional connection. Their emotional investment deepens, and in a certain pre-Oedipal psychological state, manipulated by digital capital, they undertake affective labor at tremendous cost. Much of this is “unpaid labor aimed at producing an effect, rather than directly reproducing labor power.”[19] Its influence is often achieved through Weibo practices such as “cleaning the square,” “flooding the feed,” and “bombarding” targets: expressing a positive stance toward a celebrity-related event to influence or manipulate public discourse. Alternatively, ordinary singles and albums released by a traffic-driven celebrity may achieve tens of millions or even hundreds of millions of sales. Fans thereby engage in spontaneous, frenzied, collective “traffic wars,” producing a spectacular and absurd virtual landscape of Chinese internet digital capitalism.

2. The Algorithmic Logic of Digital Capital

On the surface, the central conflict in fan-circle disorder concerns data laborers/data women workers whose “bipolar symptoms” erupt in a pre-Oedipal state. In fact, however, they are merely digital capitalism's puppets. The true instigators are online capital platforms, which require regulation and rectification even more urgently than the enormous fan population.

Since 2015, the rise of China's three internet giants, BAT - Baidu, Alibaba, and Tencent - has marked platform capital's comprehensive entry, through the internet, into popular cultural industries such as film, television, and music, and into everyday life, including finance and livelihoods. It has created an industrial system with Chinese characteristics based on online new media platforms, constructing new relationships between fans and celebrities (the three relational dimensions shown in Figure 2) and a new measurement system grounded in traffic.

Fan-circle logic under digital capital creates a vast “apparatus of desire” based on data algorithms. It determines the intensity of affective labor undertaken by fans who are simultaneously producers and consumers, while also generating products of virtual economies specific to the online traffic era: the attention economy, fan economy, and influencer economy.

Under algorithmic logic, both fans' affective labor and fans themselves are alienated. During the affective labor of generating rankings, for instance, fans refer to richly resourced celebrities backed by capital, powerful connections, and company promotion, or those who need not exert themselves, as “royalty” and “crown princes.” This reflects a certain unconscious incorporation of youth subculture within digital capitalism. Fans are not, in fact, exposing the truth about capital. Rather, the underlying traffic-centered logic manipulates their desires, prompting pre-Oedipal fans to invest endless affective labor in boosting rankings, supporting idols, driving traffic, producing data, and spending money to secure an idol's debut. This further intensifies fan-circle disorder. To boost album sales, for example, Xiao Zhan's fan club used pressure to induce fans to spend money, even leading young fans to take out online loans and fans working as teachers to call on students to buy. The result was an absurd situation in which a single digital song generated RMB 160 million in online sales in three days. All this rests on measuring the monetizable value of desire controlled by algorithms. Ultimately, an idol makes the desired debut or tops a data chart, while fans derive psychological satisfaction from virtual traffic figures. These figures rapidly become KPI results for digital capital platforms, which emerge as the real beneficiaries of this game of digital capital.

Digital capitalism has, in fact, constructed an enormous apparatus of desire extending beyond fan circles and popular culture into every aspect of everyday life: clothing, food, housing, and transport. Consider the algorithmic games introduced by Taobao during “Double Eleven”: browsing over successive days, completing tasks, and “collecting cat coins” to obtain discount coupons. Like fan-circle members, the public simultaneously become affective laborers, consumers, and producers.

3. The “Qinglang” Campaign as a Response

As the Korean-German philosopher Byung-Chul Han argues, Foucault's “disciplinary society” no longer describes contemporary society. It has been replaced by an “achievement society,” whose members become achievement-subjects and their own employers. Without external coercion or exploitation, they develop a form of self-exploitation in which perpetrator and victim become indistinguishable. Mental illnesses, including depression, become the pathological manifestations of achievement society.[20] Disorder in fan circles and its bipolar-like online hostility cannot, therefore, simply be attributed to an original sin of data laborers/data women workers. Symptoms of achievement society already permeate everyday life, livelihoods, and the economy. Through algorithmic technology, digital capitalism has developed techniques for comprehensively governing modern people, including fan-circle members. Its underlying logic will ultimately erupt toward mainstream social ideology, seeking to form new ideas and a new historical logic.

Here, on one hand, digital capitalism's algorithmic logic makes modern people self-exploiting subjects of achievement society and cogs in the enormous apparatus of desire. On the other, the “Qinglang” campaign is a forceful action engaged in an ideological and economic contest with digital capital conglomerates.

Conclusion

We hope that mainstream society can view the pre-Oedipal dependence between fans and idols from a non-criminalizing perspective and regard fans as human beings with normal psychological needs. Only then can people empathize with others, instead of falling into a bipolar affective disorder marked by paranoia, mania, depression, and the loss of a basic capacity to perceive the outside world. Fans and celebrities, men and women, and people across educational backgrounds and social classes will then be more likely to approach an ideal of equality. Society can fully activate everyone's creativity and social concern, and “positive energy” can emerge to promote mainstream society's healthy development.

Explanatory Notes

Lettered notes reproduce the original's five footnotes; bracketed numbers refer to its bibliography. The diagrams have been redrawn with English labels.

{A} “Star chasers” refers to people who follow and are fascinated by celebrity idols in entertainment, culture, or sports. In Chinese-language culture, the expression first described fans of Taiwan's Little Tigers. It later became widely used as Hong Kong's “Four Heavenly Kings” grew popular in mainland China.

{B} Descriptions of the “pre-Oedipal” state remained unclear in Freud's era. Only late in the development of psychoanalytic theory did Freud recognize the importance of the original bond with the mother, particularly the significance of the female pre-Oedipal period disclosed by women psychoanalysts.

{C} “August 14 Grand Unity” refers to August 14, 2019, when fan-circle girls posted more than 50,000 messages within 24 hours on an overseas forum advocating Hong Kong independence and smearing China, directly exposing the lies of those disrupting Hong Kong.

{D} The “February 27 Incident” refers to events beginning on February 24, 2020, when Xiao Zhan fans considered a work of fan fiction on Archive of Our Own (AO3), a nonprofit open-source repository for original and derivative creative works, insulting to Xiao Zhan and reported it to the relevant authorities. This provoked strong dissatisfaction among online literary communities, particularly fan-fiction enthusiasts. On the evening of February 27, access to online literary repositories including AO3 was blocked, provoking public anger and a widespread online boycott of Xiao Zhan and his fans.

{E} “Data women workers” refers to a group and phenomenon generated by the continually developing fan and celebrity-traffic economies on internet social media platforms. Fans coined the term themselves. A similar concept, “reposting women workers,” first appeared online in 2018. That year, a Jinjiang forum post titled “I don't think being a data woman worker is interesting” prompted discussion among different fan groups. Discussion subsequently became frequent on Zhihu, Douban, and other platforms. See Quan Hong, “Data Women Workers Trapped Online: Women's Digital Labor from the Perspective of Marxist Critical Theory,” Journal of China Women's University, 2022, no. 1, p. 87.

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